

Pittsburgh proposal aims for better bike-friendly status

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On many weekday afternoons Downtown, parking meters, signposts, standpipes and skinny trees become impromptu bike racks in the absence of the real things.

An ordinance approved Tuesday by the city Planning Commission could increase the number of racks by requiring developers to include dedicated bike parking with new projects.

"One of the huge deterrents to cycling to work is that people may buy a bike and be afraid to leave it outside on the street corner all day," said Eric Boerer, membership and project director at the advocacy group Bike Pittsburgh. "People want to know they'll be able to leave their bike without it being stolen or vandalized."

The proposal, which must be approved by City Council, requires all non-residential developments or redevelopments that change a property's use to provide a number of racks or storage lockers based upon the project's square footage. The proposal would require at least one bike-parking space for developments between 6,000 and 20,000 square feet; developments larger than 20,000 square feet must provide one space for every 10,000 square feet.

Residential developments with more than 12 units would need one bike space for every three units; parking garages with more than 40 vehicle spaces would need one bike space for every 10 vehicle spaces. And hotels, motels and "low-occupancy facilities" — such as warehouses and manufacturing sites — would have requirements based on the number of employees.

For every bike-parking space a development provides, it can subtract one vehicle-parking space otherwise required under the zoning code, up to 30 spaces. Eve Picker, a developer of residential lofts Downtown, said the substitution makes denser developments possible because bike parking takes up less space than vehicle parking.

Developing bike paths, lanes and parking is part of the city's effort to garner a "Bike-Friendly Community" rating from the Washington-based League of American Bicyclists, said Stephen Patchan, bicycle and pedestrian coordinator for the city Planning Department.

League spokeswoman Meghan Cahill said the lobbying group awards its ratings based on a community's bike infrastructure; education programs for cyclists; enforcement of traffic and safety ordinances; the activities available to

cyclists; and a community's long-term planning to accommodate cyclists.

Pittsburgh last applied for bike-friendly status in 2003 but earned only an "honorable mention," Cahill said.

Patchan said the city will reapply in February.

Bike Pittsburgh could stand to gain from the ordinance if more developers decide to buy the \$600 "Three Rivers" bike racks that the group provides through Red Star Ironworks of Millvale, said Boerer. Developers also could use racks or parking from other providers.

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